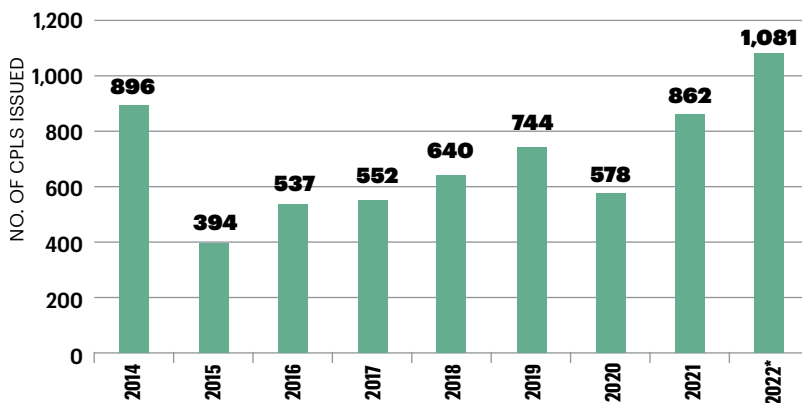


LICENCE TO FLY

THE DGCA HAS ISSUED AN AVERAGE OF 600-700 CPLs ANNUALLY OVER THE YEARS. EXPERTS ATTRIBUTE THE SPIKE IN 2022 TO CLEARING OF THE COVID-19 BACKLOG



*DATA TILL DECEMBER 6; CPL: COMMERCIAL PILOT LICENCE
SOURCE DGCA, LOK SABHA RESPONSE

Growing Traffic

- 1 India, the third largest aviation market globally, has around 9,000 pilots and 700 aircraft currently. It's a sharp contrast to China's 7,000 aircraft
- 2 Boeing expects India to require more than 2,200 aircraft over the next two decades
- 3 Domestic Indian airlines flew 123 million passengers in 2022, up 47 per cent, from 83 million in 2021, but a little below the 144 million in 2019. But a few airlines have surpassed their pre-Covid-19 numbers

Turbulence Expected



Passenger safety and flying experience can be compromised because of fatigued pilots



Fewer pilots can lead to a skewed demand-supply of planes in the air and in turn send airfares soaring



Grounded planes bleed revenue for airlines and airports

to provide [training to] these pilots," says CAPA's Agarwal. There are only 35 DGCA-approved FTOs and seven approved simulators in India. That is why an estimated 30-40 per cent of aspirants go abroad for pilot training, especially to Europe, New Zealand and Australia. That's not only a huge drain on the Indian exchequer when the country already suffers from a forex crunch, but the high costs of training also mean that many of them prefer to stay back.

The current pilot-aircraft balance is also a result of airlines sucking up pilots who were laid off and the pilots produced during the Covid-19 years. "Two years down the line, you'll also have a problem of co-pilots because the backlog and unemployment will also get used up," says FIP's Randhawa.

For instance, Air India is already facing a crunch. "The Boeing 777 and [Airbus] A320 fleets have a pilot shortage because we have started getting new aircraft. Other aircraft that were in maintenance have also come back. But the training is not as fast as aircraft arrival," says a member of the Indian Commercial Pilots Association (ICPA), requesting anonymity. ICPA

represents 900 narrow-body pilots of Air India.

The airline, now a part of the Tata group, has issued an advertisement to hire more than 1,000 pilots. Last year, it sent a letter to 55 retired pilots with plans to rehire them. "To get direct commanders (captains) suddenly is very tough with the kind of salaries it is offering," the ICPA member adds. Air India pilots and cabin crew have complained about the new salary structure that guarantees fixed pay for 40 hours. "But IndiGo pays for a blanket 70 hours even if you go on leave. That's why a lot of pilots are not willing to join Air India," the member adds. Air India has also been leasing planes before their ordered planes arrive because of increased demand. Others such as Vistara, Akasa Air and IndiGo have also begun receiving new planes.

BT's requests for comments to Air India, IndiGo, SpiceJet and Akasa Air went unanswered till the time of going to press.

TOUGH TIMES AHEAD

The ripples have already reached the flight training industry. "FTOs have lost up to 40-50 per cent of experienced instructors to airlines and this trend will only increase as more aircraft are delivered," says Hemanth, adding that a shortage of instructors is a double whammy. Ultimately, airlines need experienced pilots. So, there will be a large influx of foreign pilots through Foreign Aircrew Temporary Authorization (FATA) which is a temporary nod by DGCA to hire expat pilots, says Randhawa. "If an Indian captain earns ₹8 lakh a month, foreign captains get ₹12 lakh. That's the disparity where you demoralise your own people by giving more money to expats." Besides, many experienced pilots in India are